The popular notion that Chinese silk found its way to the eastern Mediterranean and was paid for in Roman gold is not borne out by archaeological evidence. As pointed out by historian Susan Whitfield, few Roman gold coins have been found in China but large hoards of these coins have been unearthed in locations along the Kerala coast, in particular along the port of Muziris, identified as the modern town of Kodangallur by some historians. [2] There may have been resident Roman communities in these Indian ports, just as there were Indian merchant communities settled in Egypt in the Roman era, for which there is inscriptional evidence. And, just as during the Han (206 BCE –220 CE) and the Tang (618–907 CE) dynasties, India played an important role as a transit point for goods exported from and imported by China, so too, during the Song dynasty, Indian ports on the Gujarat (Cambay), Malabar (Cochin and Calicut) and Coromandel (Nagapattinam) coasts became important trade emporia for the China trade.

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As we have seen, the Song emperors actively encouraged maritime trade and sent a number of diplomatic missions to South-East Asian countries to encourage commercial exchanges. In 971 CE , an Office of Superintendent for Maritime Trade was established in Guangzhou, followed by a second at Hangzhou in 999 CE and a third at Quanzhou in 1079 CE . For the first time in Chinese history, a permanent navy was established in 1132 CE with a standing marine corps of 52,000. Emperor Gaozhong (1127–1162 CE) wrote: ‘The profit of maritime trade contributes much to the national income. Therefore, pursuing the former custom, the people of faraway countries should be encouraged to come and sell an abundant supply of foreign goods.’

The nature and scale of the maritime trade are detailed in an account left behind by Zhao Rugua (1170–1231 CE), the Superintendent of Customs at the port of Quanzhou. He writes that pearls from Persia, ivory from Aden, myrrh from Somalia, pepper from Java and Sumatra and cotton from India were imported through the port. Zhao also spoke about Gujarat in India from where ships and merchants frequented Quanzhou. His account says